UNODC

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United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime

Agenda: Strengthening Border Control Mechanisms to Prevent the Smuggling of Illicit Drugs

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1. Letter from the Executive Board

Dear Delegates,

We are delighted to be a part of the Executive Board of the UNODC at OakJMUN. This guide exists solely, as the name states, to give you some basic information about the agenda. It cannot be your only source of information. You will need a lot more research to even scratch the surface of the agenda we are dealing with, as it is vast and complex. Setting that aside, we would still recommend you read this guide, as it will help you get started with your research if nothing else.

The intricacies of the given situation are complicated, yet not necessarily hard to understand. All you need is a little bit of time and a lot of research, and you can probably understand why we are saying this. You need to understand the problems, the causes of those problems, and come up with legitimate and applicable solutions. Thorough research will help you take it in the right direction and will prevent the committee and the debate from getting stale or stagnant. We will, however, make sure that this is a great experience for everyone involved.

The UNODC is a great committee to start with. It is easy for first timers to get into the debate and talk about issues that they can understand. If you are a first timer, we would like to reiterate what we said before: research goes a long way. MUNs can be great learning experiences, and we will do our best to make sure you have an amazing time and amazing debate.

Happy researching.

With regards,
Executive Board, UNODC

2. MUN Rules Of Procedure (ROP)

1. Roll Call

- The Chair calls on each country to declare if they are "Present" or "Present and Voting." It refers to the voting procedure on the Draft Resolution, where a delegate can vote "Yes", "No", or opt to "Abstain".
- If "Present and Voting," the delegate cannot abstain from voting. If the delegate chooses to respond with "Present", they may answer with "Present and Voting" on subsequent days, but this is not permissible for "Present and Voting" as this reply must be used consistently from that point forth.

2. Setting the Agenda

- Delegates motion to set the agenda, followed by a formal debate on which topic to discuss first. This motion requires a simple majority to pass.

3. Speakers' List

- After passing a motion to enter formal debate, delegates are placed on a speakers' list to make formal speeches. Time limits are set, and the Chair calls on delegates to speak in order.
- A delegate must raise their placard if they wish to add their name to this list. They can be on this list only once on any occasion.

4. Points

- **Point of Order:** To correct a procedural error by the Chair.
- **Point of Personal Privilege:** For personal discomfort (e.g., if the room is too cold, or if a fellow delegate cannot be heard).
- **Point of Inquiry:** To ask questions about discussion or statements in committee.
- **Point of Parliamentary Inquiry:** To ask questions with regard to the Rules of Procedure.

5. Motions

- **Motion to Suspend the Meeting:** To break for caucuses or adjourn the session.
- **Motion to Close Debate:** Ends the discussion on a topic and moves to voting. Requires a two-thirds majority.
- **Motion to Table the Topic:** Postpones debate on a topic. Requires a majority vote.

6. Yields

- **Yield to the Executive Board:** A delegate yields their remaining time from their speech to the Executive Board. It is to be used as they see fit.
- **Yield to Another Delegate:** A delegate yields their remaining time for another delegate to speak. (This delegate's permission must be sought beforehand.)
- **Yield to Points of Information:** A delegate yields their remaining time to Points of Information to the committee.
- **Yield to Comments:** A delegate yields their remaining time to comments from the committee.

7. Caucuses

- **Moderated Caucus:** The Chair controls the speaking order with shorter, focused speeches. The topic selected is a narrowed version of the agenda, chosen by the delegate who proposed the moderated caucus.
- **Unmoderated Caucus:** Informal discussion among delegates not under the moderation of the Executive Board.

8. Draft Resolutions and Amendments

- Delegates collaborate to create draft resolutions, which are formal solutions to the discussed issue.
- **Friendly Amendments:** Accepted by all sponsors without a vote.
- **Unfriendly Amendments:** Need to be voted on to be added.

9. Voting

- **Procedural Votes:** Includes motions and amendments; all members must vote.
- **Substantive Votes:** For resolutions and unfriendly amendments; only "Present and Voting" delegates may vote, and abstentions are allowed.

3. Mandate of the Committee

3.1 What UNODC Is

The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) serves as the principal institution within the United Nations system responsible for strengthening international cooperation against transnational organized crime, corruption, illicit drug trafficking, terrorism, and related threats to justice and the rule of law. Headquartered in Vienna, Austria, the Office was established in 1997 following the merger of the United Nations Drug Control Programme and the Centre for International Crime Prevention. The merger reflected a growing recognition that modern criminal networks do not operate in isolation. Drug trafficking, financial crime, corruption, arms smuggling, cybercrime, environmental offences, and human trafficking increasingly overlap, often relying on the same financial channels, logistical infrastructure, and institutional vulnerabilities. Addressing these threats demanded an integrated response rather than fragmented legal and policy frameworks.

UNODC's mandate extends beyond criminal enforcement. It functions as a norm-setting institution, a provider of technical assistance, a centre for research and data collection, and a platform for international cooperation. Its work is guided by the United Nations Charter and anchored in several multilateral treaties, most notably the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime (UNTOC), adopted in Palermo in 2000, and the United Nations Convention against Corruption (UNCAC), adopted in 2003. Together, these instruments form the backbone of the international legal framework governing organized crime and corruption, providing States with common standards for criminalization, extradition, mutual legal assistance, asset recovery, and institutional cooperation.

Unlike judicial institutions, UNODC does not prosecute offenders or investigate criminal networks directly. Responsibility for enforcement remains with sovereign States. The Office instead assists governments in strengthening domestic legal

systems, modernizing criminal justice institutions, improving investigative capacity, facilitating cross-border cooperation, and implementing obligations arising under international law. This distinction is fundamental. The effectiveness of international criminal law depends less on the existence of treaties than on the willingness and capacity of States to translate international commitments into domestic legislation, operational procedures, and sustained political action.

3.2 The Four Pillars of UNODC's Work

Pillar	What UNODC does
Organised crime	UNODC supports Member States against transnational organized crime through intelligence sharing and specialized programmes targeting human, firearms, and wildlife trafficking, as well as maritime crime and illicit financial flows.
Anti-corruption	The second pillar, anti-corruption, utilizes the UNCAC implementation review mechanism to strengthen public sector integrity, asset recovery, and transparency. By improving whistleblower protections and anti-money laundering systems, the Office addresses corruption as the institutional foundation for organized crime.
Drug control	Drug control serves as the third pillar. The Office monitors trends via the World Drug Report and promotes alternative development to reduce illicit cultivation. Modern policy balances law enforcement with public health to address both criminal supply and social demand.
Terrorism prevention	Fourth, UNODC assists in terrorism prevention by strengthening criminal justice responses to terrorist financing, border security, and prison management. This work addresses the increasing convergence between terrorist organizations and organized criminal networks.

3.3 Research and Treaty Bodies

Research remains central to the Office's work. Publications such as the Global Report on Trafficking in Persons, the World Wildlife Crime Report, and the Global Study on Homicide provide governments with evidence-based assessments of emerging criminal trends. Rather than prescribing uniform solutions, these reports identify patterns, evaluate policy effectiveness, and support informed decision-making.

Reliable data remains indispensable in a field often shaped by political narratives, incomplete reporting, and the inherently clandestine nature of organized criminal activity.

UNODC also serves as the secretariat to the Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime and the Conference of the States Parties to the United Nations Convention against Corruption. These forums provide Member States with opportunities to evaluate treaty implementation, exchange best practices, negotiate technical guidance, and strengthen international cooperation. Unlike the United Nations Security Council, UNODC possesses neither coercive authority nor enforcement powers. Its influence derives from consensus-building, technical expertise, institutional legitimacy, and the ability to facilitate cooperation between States facing shared criminal threats.

Note for Delegates

This institutional context defines the scope of committee debate. UNODC is not a forum for determining State responsibility, imposing sanctions, or authorising coercive measures under Chapter VII of the United Nations Charter. Its mandate centres on prevention, capacity building, legal harmonisation, criminal justice reform, technical assistance, and international cooperation. Effective resolutions should therefore focus on strengthening domestic institutions, improving information sharing, enhancing treaty implementation, addressing corruption, modernising investigative capabilities, and expanding cooperation against increasingly sophisticated criminal networks. While political questions inevitably arise, proposals should remain grounded in the practical competencies of the Office and the broader objectives of the United Nations system.

4. Introduction to the Agenda

Agenda: Strengthening Border Control Mechanisms to Prevent the Smuggling of Illicit Drugs.

4.1 Why Borders Matter

Every illicit drug that reaches a consumer has crossed a border at some point, or was made from chemicals that did. That is why border management sits at the centre of the international response to the world drug problem. Today it covers much more

than a fence and a checkpoint. It includes land crossings, seaports, airports, postal and express-parcel hubs, rivers, long stretches of unmonitored coastline and, increasingly, the digital channels through which drugs are ordered and paid for.

4.2 The Scale of the Problem

The scale of the problem keeps growing. UNODC estimates that 331 million people used drugs in 2024, about 6.2 per cent of the world population aged 15 to 64.[1] The same report describes markets that are more diverse, more global and more resilient, with synthetic drugs and new psychoactive substances changing where drugs are made, how they travel and who uses them. Cocaine is still the fastest-growing plant-based market. The 2025 edition recorded record production, use and seizures, including about 2,275 tonnes seized worldwide in 2023,[2] and the 2026 edition puts potential global production at roughly 4,100 tonnes in 2024.[3] Opiate supply has also shifted. Opium cultivation in Afghanistan has fallen sharply since the 2022 ban, while cultivation in Myanmar reached 53,100 hectares in 2025, up 17 per cent and the highest level since 2015.[4] UNODC also describes Myanmar as the largest producer of methamphetamine in the world.

Key Figures

- **331 million** people used drugs in 2024 (6.2 per cent of people aged 15 to 64).
- About **2,275 tonnes** of cocaine seized worldwide in 2023.
- Roughly **4,100 tonnes** of potential global cocaine production in 2024.
- **53,100 hectares** of opium in Myanmar in 2025, the highest since 2015.

4.3 Why Borders Are Hard to Control

Traffickers rely on one basic fact. The amount of legitimate movement across borders is far larger than any State can inspect. More than eighty per cent of world trade by volume goes by sea, much of it in containers,[5] and air passenger and parcel traffic has grown fast too. Customs and border agencies have to decide what to examine,

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1. UNODC, *World Drug Report 2026* (United Nations 2026), released 26 June 2026.
2. UNODC, *World Drug Report 2025* (United Nations 2025).
3. UNODC, *World Drug Report 2026*, cocaine manufacture and seizures, UNODC data portal <data.unodc.org/wdr2026>.
4. UNODC, *Myanmar Opium Survey 2025: Cultivation, Production and Implications* (December 2025).
5. UNCTAD, *Review of Maritime Transport* (annual series, United Nations).

using intelligence, risk profiling and technology, while keeping trade, travel and humanitarian movement going.

4.4 The Main Tension

This is the main tension in the agenda. Stronger controls can raise the risk and cost of trafficking, but they can also slow legitimate commerce, burden developing economies, create openings for bribery among poorly paid officials, and push traffickers onto new routes. If they are badly designed, they can also harm human rights. Delegates should therefore treat "strengthening" as better border management, which means smarter, better-resourced, rights-respecting and corruption-resistant systems that States build together, and not simply as more enforcement.

5. Causes

5.1 Profit and Steady Demand

Illicit drugs are among the most profitable goods in organised crime. Prices in distant consumer markets, such as cocaine in Oceania and Western Europe, are high enough that a few successful shipments can pay for many seized ones. UNODC also warns that drug supply is growing faster than treatment systems can respond, so demand is not shrinking to match tighter borders.[6]

5.2 Trade Volumes Far Beyond Inspection Capacity

Containers, trucks, flights and parcels cross borders in huge numbers, and no State can physically check more than a small share of them. Where scanners, trained officers, detection dogs and laboratories are missing, agencies depend on paperwork, which traffickers can forge or work around.

5.3 Corruption and Infiltration

Traffickers bribe, threaten or recruit port workers, customs officers, police, airport staff, truck drivers and shipping employees. A bribe is the cheapest way to turn a well-equipped border into a weak one, which is why anti-corruption measures under UNCAC belong in any debate on border control.

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6. UNODC, *World Drug Report 2026* (n 1).

5.4 Geography, Conflict and Weak State Presence

Long land borders, extensive coastlines, rivers and remote airstrips cannot be policed evenly. In conflict-affected areas, such as parts of Myanmar's Shan State, State authority is thin and armed or criminal groups can control crossings and production sites.

5.5 Constantly Changing Concealment Methods

UNODC and the World Customs Organization (WCO) describe the "rip-on/rip-off" technique, where drugs are slipped into a legitimately packed container before it reaches the port and taken out again at the destination by insiders.[7] Traffickers also hide drugs in ordinary goods, use couriers on flights, move them in small vessels, and send them by post and express parcel.

5.6 Synthetic Drugs, Precursors and Online Sales

Synthetic drugs are compact, potent and easy to move. They can be made close to consumers from precursor chemicals that also have legal uses and are hard to tell apart at a border. The 2026 report highlights designer drugs sold online and notes that traffickers are using technology, new substances and instability to find fresh openings.[8] For these drugs, parcels and express mail matter more than containers.

5.7 Scattered Information

Customs, police, port authorities, shipping companies and neighbouring States often each hold only part of the picture. Differences in law, data protection rules and technical systems, along with limited trust, slow down the sharing of intelligence while it is still useful.

5.8 The Displacement Effect

Pressure in one place often moves trafficking somewhere else. Strong controls at big ports push networks towards smaller ports with fewer resources, and a closed route is soon replaced by a new one. This is part of why the problem persists even when States make a real effort.

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7. WCO, "International maritime enforcement operation 'Sports Bag-2'" (27 September 2018).
8. UNODC, *World Drug Report 2026* (n 1).

6. Effects

Area	Effect
Public health	Trafficked drugs feed dependence, overdose and the spread of blood-borne diseases. The treatment gap is wide, especially for women, and highly potent synthetic products such as synthetic opioids raise the risk of death.
Violence and insecurity	Competition for trafficking corridors drives homicide, extortion and armed conflict. Transit States that produce little or no drugs can still suffer badly, because their ports and territory become valuable to criminal groups.
Corruption and weaker institutions	Constant bribery wears down the integrity of customs, police and the judiciary. It damages public trust and the rule of law and makes later reform harder.
Economic costs	Slow or poorly designed inspections delay legitimate trade and raise costs. Exporters whose goods are repeatedly used as cover can suffer reputational damage. States lose revenue to smuggling and customs fraud, and laundered money distorts markets.
Funding of conflict and wider crime	Drug money can sustain armed groups and links to arms trafficking, human trafficking and money laundering. Myanmar's growing opium economy, driven by rising prices and conflict, is a clear example.
Development and human rights	Farmers pushed into illicit cultivation by poverty and insecurity may carry the heaviest burden of enforcement. Aggressive border measures can also lead to profiling, arbitrary detention or limits on movement, so they must stay within the principles of legality, proportionality and due process.

7. Case Studies

These case studies show structural weaknesses. They do not place blame on any State, and UNODC is not the forum for doing that.

7.1 Case Study 1: Ecuador and the Container Route

UNODC names Ecuador as one of the most important cocaine transit corridors in the world, even though the country produces very little cocaine.[9] The reasons are logistical. Ecuador has a long Pacific coastline, heavy container traffic, many export routes and large legitimate exports such as bananas. According to UNODC, networks replace part of a legitimately packed consignment with cocaine while it travels by road to the port, without changing the paperwork. About two-thirds of seizures linked to consignments sent from Ecuador were made at destination ports and not during the voyage, which shows why controls matter at both ends of the supply chain. Destinations are also widening to include Oceania, where retail prices are among the highest in the world. South America as a whole accounted for 64 per cent of cocaine seized worldwide in 2024.

Questions to Consider

- How can controls at origin ports be strengthened without punishing legitimate exporters?
- What part should shipping lines, terminal operators and exporters play in securing their own supply chains?

7.2 Case Study 2: European Ports and Displacement

Western and Central Europe has now seized more cocaine than North America for six years in a row, mostly at seaports. In 2024, seizures at the major hubs of Antwerp and Rotterdam fell sharply while many smaller ports recorded increases, and more South American shipments bound for large European destinations were stopped before they arrived.[10] This is a good example of displacement. Stronger defences at the biggest gateways did not end trafficking; they changed where and how it happens. The European Union responded with its 2023 Roadmap to fight drug trafficking and organised crime,[11] which led to the European Ports Alliance in January 2024. The Alliance is a public-private partnership of customs, law enforcement and port actors, and the plan set aside EUR 200 million for modern scanning equipment.[12]

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9. UNODC, *World Drug Report 2026* (n 1); see also UNODC data portal <data.unodc.org/wdr2026>.

10. UNODC, *World Drug Report 2026*, cocaine trafficking, UNODC data portal <data.unodc.org/wdr2026>.

11. European Commission, *Communication on the EU Roadmap to fight Drug Trafficking and Organised Crime* COM(2023) 641 final (18 October 2023).

12. European Commission, "Commission launches the European Ports Alliance Public Private Partnership" (January 2024); "Launch of European Ports Alliance" (2024) *eucrim*.

Questions to Consider

- How can capacity be raised at secondary ports and at origin and transit ports, and not only at the main hubs?
- How should responsibility and costs be shared between destination and origin States?

7.3 Case Study 3: Myanmar, the Mekong and Land Borders

Southeast Asia shows how hard land borders can be to manage in a conflict setting. UNODC found that opium cultivation in Myanmar in 2025 was the highest since 2015, driven by rising opium prices, conflict and economic hardship. It also saw early signs of Myanmar heroin reaching European markets that Afghan heroin used to supply.[13] In the wider Mekong region, methamphetamine seizures have grown steadily, with a record of more than a billion tablets in 2023.[14] Porous borders, limited State control over production areas and the easy transport of synthetic drugs make this very different from a container port. Regional cooperation, alternative livelihoods and control of precursor chemicals matter as much as checkpoints.

Questions to Consider

- Which border measures work where the State has limited control over production areas?
- How can regional frameworks and development assistance be combined?

8. Regional Responses

8.1 European Union

The 2023 Roadmap and the European Ports Alliance bring customs, law enforcement and the port sector together against high-risk networks. EMPACT, the EU platform against criminal threats, and Europol support joint operations and

13. UNODC, *Myanmar Opium Survey 2025* (n 4).

14. UNODC, *Synthetic Drugs in East and Southeast Asia* (annual series, UNODC Regional Office for Southeast Asia and the Pacific).

information exchange. In 2025, ministers also discussed working with source and transit countries so that trafficking is tackled further upstream.[15]

8.2 Latin America and the Caribbean

The Inter-American Drug Abuse Control Commission (CICAD) of the Organization of American States and police networks such as AMERIPOL provide regional platforms. Many ports in the region take part in the UNODC-WCO Container Control Programme, and UNODC reported Port Control Units in 14 Latin American and Caribbean countries by 2018.[16]

8.3 Africa

West Africa became a transit zone for cocaine travelling from South America to Europe. The ECOWAS Regional Action Plan against illicit drug trafficking and the UNODC-supported West Africa Coast Initiative (WACI), which set up Transnational Crime Units, aim to build national and regional capacity. African airports also take part in AIRCOP, a UNODC, WCO and INTERPOL project aimed at couriers and air cargo.

8.4 Southeast Asia

The Mekong MOU on Drug Control and successive ASEAN work plans on securing communities against illicit drugs frame cooperation on cross-border enforcement, precursor control and alternative development. UNODC supports the work with surveys and monitoring.[17]

8.5 Central and South-West Asia

The Paris Pact Initiative, a UNODC-supported partnership on Afghan opiates, and the Triangular Initiative of Afghanistan, Iran and Pakistan support intelligence sharing and joint border efforts along the traditional opiate routes.

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15. Ports Europe, "European Ports Alliance outlines new steps to fight drug trafficking" (24 July 2025).

16. UNODC, "UNODC-WCO Container Control Programme reports record high cocaine seizures in Latin America and the Caribbean" (April 2018).

17. UNODC, *Myanmar Opium Survey 2025* (n 4), noting that the survey is carried out under the framework of the Mekong MOU on Drug Control.

One Lesson Repeats

Agreements work best when they are backed by real operational links, such as shared databases, liaison officers and joint units, and not only by political declarations.

9. International Responses

9.1 Legal Framework

Three UN drug control conventions form the base: the 1961 Single Convention on Narcotic Drugs,[18] the 1971 Convention on Psychotropic Substances[19] and the 1988 Convention against Illicit Traffic in Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances.[20] The 1988 Convention is the most relevant to border control. It covers:

Provision	What it covers
Article 11	Controlled delivery
Article 12	Monitoring of precursor chemicals
Article 15	Commercial carriers
Article 17	Illicit traffic by sea
Other articles	Mutual legal assistance and extradition

UNTOC and UNCAC add tools against organised criminal groups and against the corruption that undermines border agencies.[21] The International Narcotics Control Board (INCB) monitors how the treaties are applied and runs tools such as the Pre-Export Notification Online system for precursors. Policy direction comes from the Commission on Narcotic Drugs, the outcome document of the 2016 General

18. Single Convention on Narcotic Drugs (adopted 30 March 1961, entered into force 13 December 1964) 520 UNTS 151.

19. Convention on Psychotropic Substances (adopted 21 February 1971, entered into force 16 August 1976) 1019 UNTS 175.

20. United Nations Convention against Illicit Traffic in Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (adopted 20 December 1988, entered into force 11 November 1990) 1582 UNTS 95.

21. United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime (adopted 15 November 2000, entered into force 29 September 2003) 2225 UNTS 209; United Nations Convention against Corruption (adopted 31 October 2003, entered into force 14 December 2005) 2349 UNTS 41.

Assembly Special Session on the world drug problem,[22] and the 2019 Ministerial Declaration.[23]

9.2 UNODC-WCO Container Control Programme (CCP)

Launched in 2004, the CCP helps States set up joint Port Control Units and Air Cargo Control Units that use risk profiling to target high-risk containers without disrupting trade. By 2019 its units had seized more than 300 tonnes of cocaine in total,[24] and in 2020 alone they seized over 100 tonnes, with the programme operating in 73 countries.[25] In 2018, operation "Sports Bag-2" involved 44 countries and 52 seaports, targeted rip-on/rip-off contamination, and led to 14 seizures and more than 5.8 tonnes of cocaine.[26]

9.3 Airport Communication Project (AIRCOP)

AIRCOP is run by UNODC with the WCO and INTERPOL. It sets up Joint Airport Interdiction Task Forces at international airports in Africa, Latin America, the Caribbean and Southeast Asia and connects officers to INTERPOL's I-24/7 and the WCO's CENcomm for real-time information exchange. The task forces have reported more than 6,000 arrests and 6,700 seizures.[27] Together, the CCP and AIRCOP involve 86 countries.[28]

9.4 Other UNODC Programmes

The Global Maritime Crime Programme supports maritime law enforcement. Work on cybercrime and illicit financial flows addresses online markets and money laundering. UNODC regional programmes, forensic and laboratory support and illicit crop monitoring supply data and technical capacity.

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22. UNGA Res S-30/1 (19 April 2016) UN Doc A/RES/S-30/1.

23. Commission on Narcotic Drugs, Ministerial Declaration on strengthening our actions at the national, regional and international levels to accelerate the implementation of our joint commitments to address and counter the world drug problem (2019).

24. WCO, "UNODC-WCO Container Control Programme reaches 300 metric tons of cocaine seized globally" (18 July 2019).

25. WCO, "Amidst obstacles posed by pandemic, Container Control Programme cocaine seizures surpassed 100 ton milestone in 2020" (26 February 2021).

26. WCO (n 7).

27. European Union, "AIRCOP VI: Airport Communication Project", Global Threats project page.

28. WCO, "UNODC and WCO release the Airport Communication Programme and Container Control Programme Annual Report 2023" (4 April 2024).

9.5 Partner Organisations

The WCO provides standards such as the SAFE Framework of Standards for secure trade and operational communication tools.[29] INTERPOL provides databases and coordinates operations. Development banks help fund infrastructure, and the private sector, including shipping lines, port operators, express carriers and chemical companies, increasingly shares information and security practice.

9.6 Remaining Gaps

Even with this architecture, UNODC data show that seizures can rise at the same time as production and use. Programme coverage is uneven and depends on voluntary funding, and UNODC cannot compel any State to act. Many border officials work with limited equipment and low pay, data sharing is patchy, and fast-changing synthetic drug markets and online sales challenge systems built for plant-based drugs moving in containers.

10. Way Forward and Conclusion

Border control works as a system, and its weakest link decides how strong it really is. Within UNODC's mandate, delegates may wish to think about the following areas.

10.1 Areas to Consider

1. **Intelligence-led, risk-based controls.** Expand targeting units and the use of advance passenger and cargo information, so that scarce inspection resources go where the risk is highest and blanket inspections do not choke legitimate trade.
2. **Technology and laboratories.** Support scanners, detection equipment, rapid field-testing kits and forensic laboratories that can identify new psychoactive substances and precursors. Funding should cover maintenance and running costs and not only the initial purchase.
3. **Integrity of border personnel.** Back vetting, staff rotation, whistleblower protection, fair pay and anti-corruption units at ports, airports and land crossings, using UNCAC-based measures against infiltration by criminal networks.

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29. WCO, *SAFE Framework of Standards to Secure and Facilitate Global Trade* (2005, as updated).

4. **Cooperation along the whole chain.** Strengthen links between origin, transit and destination countries through joint units, liaison officers and port-to-port information exchange. Public-private partnerships can give shipping lines, terminal operators, postal and express carriers and chemical companies clear reporting duties and legal safeguards.
5. **Precursors and new threats.** Reinforce precursor monitoring and pre-export notification, build the ability to screen parcels and mail, and cooperate on online marketplaces within national law.
6. **Support for transit and fragile States.** Give technical and financial help to States that are used as corridors but have few resources, with attention to secondary ports and remote land and sea borders so that displacement is limited.
7. **Balancing security with trade, health and rights.** Border measures should respect legality, proportionality and due process, and protect legitimate trade and humanitarian movement. Supply-side measures should also be linked to prevention, treatment and alternative development, in line with the balanced approach that UNODC promotes.
8. **Measuring success.** Seizure figures alone can mislead, since rising seizures may mean better enforcement or a bigger market. Better indicators include disrupted networks, prosecutions of organisers and corrupt facilitators, how quickly cross-border information is shared, and the cost and delay imposed on lawful trade.

10.2 Conclusion

The international community already has most of what it needs to make borders harder for traffickers to exploit, including treaties, programmes and partners. What is still missing is steady implementation, enough long-term resources for the most exposed States, and cooperation that keeps pace with traffickers who adapt quickly. Delegates are encouraged to propose practical, legally sound and cooperative measures that respect sovereignty, strengthen institutions and stay within what UNODC can do.

11. Sources for Further Research

- UNODC, *World Drug Report 2026* and *World Drug Report 2025*, including the online data portal at data.unodc.org.
- UNODC, *Myanmar Opium Survey 2025: Cultivation, Production and Implications* (December 2025).
- UNODC and WCO, Container Control Programme and AIRCOP Annual Reports, including the 2023 report.
- Single Convention on Narcotic Drugs (1961), Convention on Psychotropic Substances (1971), the 1988 Convention against Illicit Traffic, UNTOC (2000) and UNCAC (2003).
- European Commission, *EU Roadmap to fight Drug Trafficking and Organised Crime* (October 2023) and European Ports Alliance documents.
- INCB annual reports, the WCO SAFE Framework of Standards and the outcome document of the 2016 UN General Assembly Special Session on drugs.

Please Note

Delegates should check all statistics against the primary reports above before citing them in committee.

12. Questions a Resolution Must Answer (QARMA)

1. How can UNODC help States target high-risk consignments and passengers without disrupting legitimate trade and travel?
2. What technical assistance should be prioritised for transit States and secondary ports, and how can it be funded over the long term?
3. How can States build corruption-resistant border institutions and protect officials who resist criminal pressure?
4. How can cooperation between origin, transit and destination countries, including real-time intelligence sharing, be made faster and more trusting?

5. What role should the private sector (shipping lines, terminals, express carriers, chemical companies, online platforms) play, and under what legal safeguards?
6. How should border controls adapt to synthetic drugs, precursor chemicals and online sales delivered by post and express parcel?
7. How can border measures stay consistent with human rights, due process and public health objectives?
8. How should the effectiveness of border-control initiatives be measured beyond the volume of seizures?